

LangoBee's funnel, audited

Week 1, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- The AARRR framework mapped to LangoBee's actual PostHog events
- The real June 2026 numbers: ~50 users, 4 WAU, \$0 MRR
- Cohort anatomy: May 18, May 25, June 1
- Why word_lookup_opened is a signal and trial_started is silent
- Choosing a north-star metric for a comprehensible-input app

AARRR mapped to LangoBee

Five stages, LangoBee edition

Dave McClure's AARRR framework (2007) names five conversion stages. Every product maps its own events to them.

Stage	LangoBee event	Status
Acquisition	Pageview on langobee.com	Firing
Activation	First reading_event (kind = 'page_read')	Firing
Retention	reading_event on day 7+ after signup	Measurable
Revenue	trial_started	Zero events ever
Referral	Share action on shorts feed	1 event in 30 days

Revenue stage has zero events. The paywall is wired; no human has entered it.

(McClure, 2007)

The acquisition picture

30-day acquisition attribution (direct + identified channels):

- **Direct / Discord:** 174 people. This is the founder manually recruiting from a ~30-person Discord.
- **google.com:** 21 people
- **t.co (Twitter):** 5 people

No repeatable paid channel exists. The only proven acquisition channel is founder-driven hand-recruitment. At 4 WAU and \$0 MRR, this is the correct channel: manual recruiting surfaces real users cheaply before any channel investment.

(Cheung, 2019: start with active users before investing in acquisition)

The real numbers: June 2026 snapshot

De-alted (founder, alt, and bot accounts removed):

- **Real profiles:** approximately 50 humans out of 103 registered
- **WAU:** 4 (last 7 days, authenticated, de-alted)
- **MAU:** 31 (last 30 days, authenticated, de-alted)
- **MRR:** \$0. Zero trial_started events ever.

The raw dashboard shows 103 profiles. That number feels like progress. The de-alted number is the one that determines whether acquisition spend would have a positive return.

4 WAU is the honest baseline.

Cohort anatomy

Three cohort weeks, three stories

Cohort week	Signups	Activated	Returned
May 18	15	12 (80%)	6 (40%)
May 25	19	7 (37%)	3 (16%)
June 1	52	1 (2%)	unknown

Three completely different profiles in three consecutive weeks.

May 18: strong activation, reasonable return. These are likely real comprehensible-input learners recruited directly.

May 25: lower activation, lower return. Broader recruiting, lower-intent audience.

June 1: 51 bots. One real human.

What the May 18 cohort tells you

12 of 15 activated. 6 returned. This is the product working for someone.

The users who activated in that cohort are the signal. Look at what they did:

- They are likely from the Refold / Dreaming Spanish comprehensible-input community
- They used the reader or the YouTube viewer, not the shorts feed
- word_lookup_opened is the top product action at 5,225 events in 30 days: the tap-a-word loop works for this audience

The May 18 cohort is the evidence that the product solves a real problem. It is also the reason not to pivot to a completely different thesis in week 2.

What the June 1 cohort tells you

52 signups, 1 activation. Do not celebrate this as acquisition traction.

Bot-detection checklist for any cohort week:

1. Activation rate below 5%: strong bot signal
2. Email domains: check for known junk TLDs (a7gi.ru, host315.net)
3. Auth provider: all password, no OAuth: bot signal
4. Time to signup: burst of signups in a short window: automated

The June 1 spike almost certainly came from a credential-stuffing or spam-registration script that found the signup endpoint. It produces no revenue, no retention, no signal. Exclude it and move on.

Choosing a north-star metric

What a north-star metric must do

Rachitsky's (2021) definition: the single number that best represents the value your product delivers to users. It must be:

- A leading indicator of revenue, not revenue itself
- Something users do (not something you do)
- Measurable with the tools you have today

Six NSM categories (Rachitsky, 2021):

1. Revenue (e.g., MRR): lagging, not the NSM
2. Customer growth (e.g., paid subscribers): lagging
3. Consumption growth (e.g., words read): leading
4. Engagement (e.g., sessions per week): leading
5. Growth efficiency: not applicable at this stage
6. User experience: too broad to track

LangoBee's NSM candidates

Three candidates, each tied to a specific product behavior:

Candidate A: Words encountered per week (de-alted)

- What it measures: volume of target-language exposure
- Why it leads revenue: comprehension progress drives retention
- Query: `SELECT count(*) FROM reading_events WHERE kind = 'word_seen'`

Candidate B: Days with at least one reading session (de-alted, last 28 days)

- What it measures: habit formation, not just binge sessions
- Why it leads revenue: habit is the retention predictor for subscription products

Candidate C: word_lookup_opened events per WAU per week

- What it measures: depth of vocabulary engagement per active user
- Why it leads revenue: users who look up words are actively learning, not browsing

Most founders track the wrong things, counting aggregate registrations and pageviews instead of conversion rates at each funnel stage that show whether users are getting value. (Paraphrased)

Dave McClure (2007)

Startup Metrics for Pirates: AARRR!!, SlideShare

The \$0 MRR problem, stated plainly

Stripe is wired. The paywall exists. The trial flow exists. Zero humans have entered it.

This is not a pricing problem. It is a sequencing problem.

You cannot learn whether \$7.99/mo is the right price when no user has reached the trial screen. The funnel breaks before revenue.

The correct diagnosis: activation and retention come before monetization. The reading and session section this week establish the honest baseline. Weeks 3-5 fix activation. Weeks 6-8 address monetization. Spending on acquisition or pricing experiments now is spending ahead of learning.

(McClure, 2007: fix the leakiest stage, not the one you prefer to fix)

Take-aways

1. LangoBee's AARRR funnel has events firing at acquisition, activation, and retention; the revenue stage has zero events ever, which is the primary diagnostic.
2. The June 2026 snapshot is: approximately 50 real users, 4 de-acted WAU, 31 MAU, \$0 MRR. These are the honest baseline numbers.
3. Cohort analysis separates three completely different stories: strong May 18 week (real CI learners), declining May 25, bot-dominated June 1.
4. word_lookup_opened at 5,225 events in 30 days is the product working; it is the leading signal to track as a north-star metric candidate.
5. The correct sequence is activation and retention first, monetization after. The funnel breaks before revenue; fixing acquisition or pricing now is out of order.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Ground truth and the de-alted dashboard" at `/c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk01`
- **Section this week:** Rebuild the de-alted dashboard from raw HogQL and SQL; fill in the cohort table; diagnose the June 1 spike
- **HW1 (going out this week):** The honest dashboard: your de-alted WAU, MAU, and cohort table with bot-detection notes
- **Next week (Wk 2):** Thesis discipline: the locked decision and when to pivot